

compromised, these findings brought to light the increasingly sophisticated techniques used by hackers to bring even the biggest corporations to their knees. So there's no doubt that if a player as big as Google can be a target, then even the most careful of users are vulnerable to these loopholes, and the first and foremost step that anyone who owns a PC, laptop or smartphone should take is install anti-virus on their device.

While choosing your anti-virus, its best to go for the big names. Windows has a built-in Windows Defender, though most security experts recommend installing additional AV software. In its defence, since Windows Defender is free and built-in to Windows 10, it doesn't harass you with pop-ups and requests for money, and is lighter than some competing antivirus solutions – making it the preferred basic line of defence by a lot of people. Yet, if you're constantly installing new software and engaging in high-risk behaviour, paid anti-viruses like Norton, McAfee and Kaspersky etc are known for their detection rates, and are considered safe bets. The same would go for Macs, and Linux is known to not require an anti-virus, though that largely depends on how technically informed the Linux user is, which a majority are. Free anti-virus solutions like Avast, Avira and AVG are just as good as the paid ones except you don't get priority support. The core detection engines offered by free ones are the same as their paid versions in most cases.

Though installing anti-virus software is the recommended way to go, enabling a Firewall on your device also goes a long way, though it can't provide the same level of protection an anti-virus would. A software Firewall, just like a device-based hardware Firewall, would filter information coming through the Internet into your system. If an incoming packet of information is marked by the filters, it is not allowed through. In large corporate institutions or any business that has a small to large private network it wishes to protect from outside attacks, the main function of a Firewall is that it stops anyone on the outside from logging onto a computer in the internal network. Since most home networks would not be subject to such an invasion, a Firewall might not perform the exact way you'd expect it to. Nevertheless, when it comes to cyber-security, more is merrier, and you can never go wrong with a Firewall. ZoneAlarm and Comodo are two well known free solutions you might want to try out.

Before you plug in that USB stick...

There are several more precautions one can take to prevent malware from external sources. Making sure the software you install is from a verified